

What Is Reality Drift?

A definition note on how functional systems lose corrective contact with the conditions they represent.

A. Jacobs | Reality Drift Framework

Reality Drift is the condition in which a system remains operational and internally coherent while the representations guiding it progressively lose corrective contact with the reality they are meant to track, describe, or govern.

The Central Distinction

Reality Drift distinguishes internal coherence from corrective contact. A system can continue producing plausible explanations, improving metrics, completed procedures, and stable outputs even as its relationship to external conditions weakens. Its internal consistency may increase while its representations become less answerable to what they claim to represent.

A representation can also reorganize the conditions later treated as evidence. Reality Drift becomes self-reinforcing when system behavior changes the conditions subsequently observed, while the same representational logic continues to determine what counts as evidence.

This is why coherence does not necessarily indicate contact, and continued operation does not demonstrate alignment.

The Minimum Structure of Drift

Drift is not simply inaccuracy. Four conditions make it a system dynamic.

1. **A referent.** A condition, outcome, or lived reality exists outside the representation.
2. **A representation.** A metric, model, document, category, narrative, or interface stands in for it.
3. **Selection pressure.** The system rewards what performs well inside the representation.
4. **Weak correction.** Feedback from the referent is delayed, filtered, costly, or unable to change the system.

The Drift Principle

Representations can be compressed, optimized, distributed, and reused faster than real-world conditions can correct them. Drift increases when a system's capacity to transform and reuse representations exceeds its capacity to test and revise them.

The result is survivable wrongness. A representation can remain useful to the system after it has become misleading about the world.

Why Drift Is Difficult to Detect

Ordinary warning systems look for interruption, contradiction, or collapse. Reality Drift often produces none of these at first. The system continues to work according to its own definitions of success.

- Outputs remain coherent.
- Performance indicators remain stable or improve.
- Procedures continue to reach formal completion.
- The original reference point becomes harder to reconstruct.

Boundary

Reality Drift is not a synonym for error, bias, misinformation, unreality, or institutional failure. Those may be episodes or manifestations of drift. The concept names the structural condition that lets divergence accumulate while normal operation continues.

It also does not claim that representations are avoidable. Complex systems require abstraction. The question is whether representations remain answerable to what they represent.

Compact Diagnostic

- What real condition is this representation supposed to preserve?
- What proxy or output is the system actually selecting for?
- What evidence can still contradict the representation?
- What happens when the representation is wrong but remains operationally useful?

Relation to the Concept System

The Representation Stack locates where distance accumulates. Semantic Fidelity evaluates what meaning survives translation. The Drift Principle explains why divergence compounds. Constraint Collapse describes the loss of correction. The Optimization Trap describes reinforcement around a proxy. Synthetic Realness, Cognitive Drift, and Filter Fatigue describe recognizable effects.

Concise Definition

Reality Drift describes the progressive loss of corrective contact between a system's representations and the real-world conditions they are meant to track, even while the system remains functional and internally coherent.